



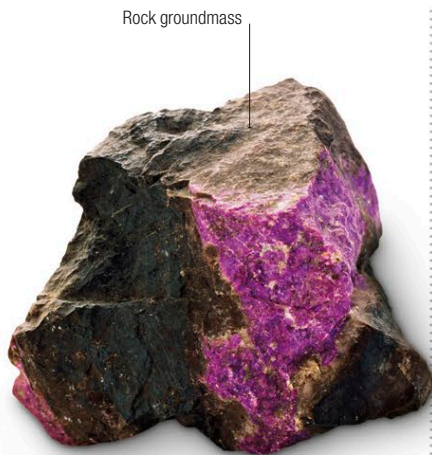
Sugilite

△ Group of top-grade pieces of sugilite rough

Sugilite was discovered in 1944, but it was only recognized as a mineral in 1976. It is most commonly found in massive or granular form, and rarely found as crystals; when crystals do occur, they are small – less than 2cm (¾in) across. Its colour can be pale to deep pink, brownish-yellow, or purple, with deep hues of the latter commanding the most value. It is always cut *en cabochon* when used as a gemstone, while pebbles are sometimes polished in rock tumblers. Sugilite is named after its co-discoverer, Japanese petrologist Ken-ichi Sugi.

Specification

Chemical name Potassium, sodium lithosilicate | **Formula** $\text{KNa}_2(\text{Fe,Mn,Al})_2\text{Li}_3\text{Si}_{12}\text{O}_{30}\cdot\text{H}_2\text{O}$ | **Colours** Pink, brown-yellow, or purple | **Structure** Hexagonal | **Hardness** 5.5–6.5
SG 2.73–2.79 | **RI** 1.60–1.61 | **Lustre** Vitreous
Streak White | **Locations** Canada, Japan, South Africa, Italy



Sugilite in rock | Rough | Within this specimen, a layer of vividly coloured, gem-quality sugilite can be seen sandwiched between two layers of rock.



Sugilite slice | Rough | This slice of sugilite rough shows good colour along with black manganese minerals. The cutter will select the best areas for a cabochon.



Polished piece | Cut | This polished piece of high-grade sugilite can be used as a cabochon, or simply enjoyed as a fine mineral specimen by a collector.



Cabochon | Cut | The finest gem-quality sugilite is usually cut into cabochons, such as this elongated oval, high-domed example. It contains a number of small inclusions.

Rare carving | Carved | Carved in Idar Oberstein, Germany, from the highest-grade South African sugilite, these herons stand on a base of calcite and have yellow jasper beaks.



The forgotten gem

Sugilite's long road to recognition

Several decades passed between the time when Professor Sugi first discovered sugilite in 1944 and the time by which gem material was found. The original Japanese finds were tiny yellow crystals with no gem value. In 1955, some dark pink crystals were discovered in India, which were also identified as sugilite, but these were not cuttable. Finally, in 1975, a seam of rich purple sugilite was found at a manganese mine in South Africa, the first commercial source.



Tumbled gem The highest-quality sugilite can be fashioned into exquisite cabochons and carvings.